

**Time:** 5 minutes**Outcome:** Determine equilibrium, shortages, surpluses, adjustment, and comparative statics.**Difficulty:** ●○○ Beginner

Shortages and Surpluses



THE CORE IDEA

A shortage occurs when quantity demanded exceeds quantity supplied; a surplus occurs when quantity supplied exceeds quantity demanded. A shortage occurs when quantity demanded exceeds quantity supplied. Quantity demanded exceeds quantity supplied, so there is a shortage. Shortages push price upward. A price above equilibrium creates a surplus because quantity supplied exceeds quantity demanded.



HOW TO RECOGNIZE IT

- At the current price, buyers want 180 units and sellers offer 120 units.
- A price above equilibrium creates a surplus because quantity supplied exceeds quantity demanded.
- A price below equilibrium creates a shortage because quantity demanded exceeds quantity supplied.
- A surplus exists when quantity supplied is greater than quantity demanded.

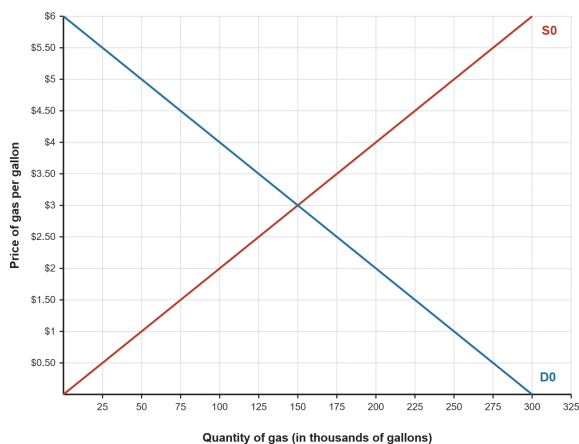


WATCH OUT

A common mistake is to reverse shortage and price pressure. Quantity demanded exceeds quantity supplied, so there is a shortage. Shortages push price upward.



WORKED EXAMPLE: MEASURING A SHORTAGE



At a price of \$2 per gallon, the graph shows quantity demanded of 200 thousand gallons and quantity supplied of 100 thousand. Because buyers want 100 thousand more gallons than sellers offer, the market has a shortage of $200 - 100 = 100$ thousand gallons. Upward pressure on price follows.



CHECK YOURSELF

At the current price, quantity demanded exceeds quantity supplied. What market condition exists?

**READY?**

Return to the game and master this concept.